



The Sun's colour is best seen when reflected in water. Never look directly at the Sun.

The Sun

Our Sun is a star, but it is closer to us than any other star. Like all stars, it is a massive ball of burning gas, fed by constant explosions in its core. Without it, our planet would be lifeless.



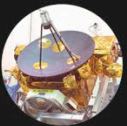
Shimmering lights can light up the skies towards the Earth's polar regions.

Solar wind

The Sun sends out a stream of invisible particles, called the solar wind. When these pass the Earth's North and South poles, they can create stunning colours.

Investigating the Sun

Various space probes have been designed to study the Sun.



Ulysses was launched in 1990 to look at the Sun's polar regions.



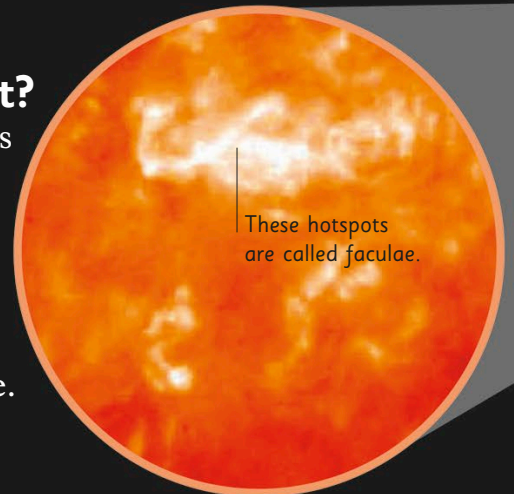
SOHO was launched in 1995 to observe the Sun and solar activity.



TRACE was launched in 1998 to study the Sun's atmosphere.

A hot spot?

White areas show places where the Sun's surface temperature is higher than elsewhere. Cooler, dark areas, called sunspots, sometimes appear on the surface.



These hotspots are called faculae.

Long lived

The Sun was born just under five billion years ago. Although it burns four million tonnes (tons) of fuel each second, it is so big that it will continue to burn for another five billion years.